

her "several times a day" since Sept. 11, asking for his wisdom.

"He said we needed to pull together," she said. "He compared it to Pearl Harbor. He said he did not think (the war against terrorism) would be a contained war, or a brief war. He talked like it could be another world war."

His friend Ed Egeland told the church: "Like most people in that war, they don't share stories about the battles. He had a tough time in that battle of Omaha Beach, where so many of his friends were lost."

But Egeland said that when Tom Brokaw published his book "The Greatest Generation" in 1998, the same year that "Saving Private Ryan" came out, veterans of World War II started talking. Brokaw's book quotes Department of Veteran Affairs estimates that 32,000 World War II veterans die every month.

When Smith started opening up, he told his family and friends about the horror of Omaha Beach, of stepping off a landing craft into the hellfire of Nazi machine guns.

"I took him to see Private Ryan," Bjorneboe said. "Afterwards, he was very quiet. I asked him if it was like that."

He said, "Pretty much."

He opened up even more to his two grandchildren. Before the funeral, Smith's granddaughter, Michelle Arthurs, recounted how he talked of his encounters with Germans. And about the crucifix he got from a French family that hid from the Nazis later in the war.

"He still has that crucifix," she said. "It's with some other war mementos. He has a watch from a German soldier."

Granted, this generation wasn't perfect. It wasn't until the 1960s and 1970s and the Civil Rights movement and Vietnam that we began to question America's collective morality. The Boomers did make major contributions there.

But neither we Boomers or Generation X would be questioning jack if Smith's generation hadn't stepped forward. When called upon, they kicked butt, and saved civilization.

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TODD SUMLIN - STAFF PHOTO

N.C. State University student Clark McCullough feeds fluids to a red-tailed hawk Tuesday at the Carolina Raptor Center. Veterinary students are spending a week at the center for a closer look.

Future vets learn firsthand during stint at Raptor Center

NCSU students say experience dealing with birds is priceless

BY MARGARET LAWSON
Staff Writer

It would take just one slip, and those inch-long talons could inflict some serious pain.

But that didn't seem to deter any of the closely attentive visitors at the Carolina Raptor Cen-

ter Tuesday.

In fact, the six veterinary students from N.C. State University clustered even closer for a better view, eager to lend a hand if necessary, as a red-tailed hawk was force-fed its morning energy drink.

"There is more strength in that bird's foot than in an adult man's hand," warned Mathias Engelman, the center's rehabilitation coordinator.

"It's only a three-pound bird, but it takes more than one person to orize that 'oot open."

The students and two NCSU professors are spending this week at the center as one of several areas of concentration the vet curriculum offers. Students come every year to learn about the big birds.

This week, several students are getting their first experience handling and caring for injured raptors.

"The students get a unique experience here because of the sheer volume of birds they can see," said NCSU professor of

SEE BIRDS | 3B



TODD SUMLIN - STAFF PHOTO

N.C. State University student Amy Hawley releases a hawk Tuesday at the Carolina Raptor Center. A motorist brought the bird to be checked for injuries after it was struck by another car.

Future vets see avian care up close at Raptor Center

Birds *from 1B*

avian medicine, Laurie Degernes.

At this time of year, while the raptors are migrating, the center receives up to eight birds a day that have flown into windows or been hit by cars.

"By the end of the week, the students will all be confident handling the birds, doing physicals, treatments and primary care," Degernes said.

Most of these students will not end up working with raptors - at least not exclusively.

"Probably most of them will work in veterinary practices where people will randomly show up with wildlife," said Betty O'Leary, a rehabilitation assistant at the center. "So having the advance knowledge of dealing with these birds is an advantage, because a lot of vets don't know much about birds."

"More people are buying exotic pets like parrots, and their anatomy is really quite similar."

This is exactly what some students want to spend their lives doing. For instance, Deena Brenner, 23, wants to be a vet in a zoo or wildlife park.

"These birds fascinate me. They're beautiful," Brenner said. "This experience has been so good because the park is incredibly well run and everyone is so

caring. I'm learning a lot."

As another rescued bird arrived - a Cooper's hawk that had flown into the side of a van - the students and their supervisors put on protective gloves and sprang into examination mode.

Fortunately, the bird was just dazed, so they examined it, tagged its leg for monitoring and released it about 20 minutes later.

As the students and center staffers watched, the bird flew to safety in a tree.

"They seem fragile in so many ways, but it's amazing what they can recover from," Brenner observed. "It was pretty exciting to see it out in the wild again."

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